and Mohali. He was joined at a pivotal team meeting in the UAE by Hugh Morris, managing director of England Cricket, and Sean Morris, chief executive of the Professional Cricketers' Association.

Reg insisted it was safe to return and promised blanket security. I had been digging around, researching the situation as best I could. Indian newspapers were talking about us being protected by a phalanx of 300 commandos and 5,000 other security personnel. A thousand police were assigned to enforcing a lockdown at the team hotel – superficially reassuring, but hardly likely to encourage a settled state of mind. Knowing Reg as I do now, a decade on, I should have trusted him. His responsibility, his priority, has manifestly been our safety. Yet, at the time, I was cynical about the influence of the Indian cricket authorities on the world game. They were certainly not short of financial muscle.

Cricket had been in the crosshairs before. Three New Zealand teams had been caught up in terrorist suicide attacks, twice in Sri Lanka, in 1987 and 1993, and again in Pakistan in 2002. As things turned out, we were little more than three months away from the attack on the Sri Lankan team bus in Lahore, which sadly succeeded in its primary political aim of isolating Pakistan from the rest of the world.

Something didn't feel right. Freddie and Steve Harmison were dubious about returning. Jimmy and I were the last to agree to do so. It was a hugely sensitive situation; Graeme Swann spoke of waiting for ten years for a chance to make his Test debut and was determined to fight for the opportunity. He told us: 'This could be my only chance to play Test cricket, so I'm going.' Such passion swayed many of the team because they identified with the force of his ambition.

I'm so glad we did so, because we saw at first hand the healing power of sport. On arrival in Chennai each of us was presented with a garland of flowers and marked with a *tilaka* , the traditional Hindu red spot placed on the forehead to signify health and prosperity. The sense of respect and gratitude from the Indian public was almost overpowering.

Cricket seemed an indulgence, and character had a different connotation, but Straussy showed his substance by trying to carry us over the line in Chennai with scores of 123 and 108, supported by Paul Collingwood's second-innings 108. Swanny made his debut and featured in a footnote of cricket history when India chased down 387 to win by six wickets on the final day.